

CELEBRATING 20 YEARS OF THE WILDLIFE GARDEN

The Museum's Wildlife Garden was the far-sighted vision of Clive Jermy, who worked in the Botany Department until 1992. The idea was to represent the major habitats that exist in lowland England, showing the natural diversity of the wider landscape within a day trip of the capital. Researcher **Steve Brooks** picks up the story.

The Wildlife Garden is an educational resource enabling visitors to immerse themselves in the English countryside in the middle of London. It is not a typical wildlife garden – essentially a patch of uncultivated ground where nature is left to get on with it. Instead it is akin to a living gallery – linked to and complementing other exhibits inside the Museum, which explore ecology, ecosystems and biodiversity.

FROM VISION TO REALITY

Planning for the garden began in the late 1980s, with Clive Jermy convening an advisory group with a representative from each of the science departments and the exhibitions team. I was the entomology representative and am now the only member of staff still here who was involved in the early stages. Landscape architect Mark



Top to bottom An audience deeply engrossed by the findings of naturalist Tom Thomas during Big Nature Day. View from the pond-dipping platform, across white water-lilies and open water to the reed bed. Along the board walk in the fen habitat with meadowsweet, yellow and purple loosestrife. Young visitors examining the contents of a sweep net during an event in the Wildlife Garden

this the best of the various meeting venues available in the Museum.

PONDLIFE

After two decades, each one of the habitats is still recognisably distinct and supports different plants and animals. Remarkably some, such as the chalk grassland and woodland, have been colonised by species typical of those habitats, including grass vetchling, six-spot burnet moths and broad-leaved helleborine, even though South Kensington is miles from the nearest wild examples.

The ponds are an example of a habitat that was absent from the Museum grounds before the garden's creation and this has inevitably resulted in the arrival of many new species. The only animals to be introduced in the early days were frogs, toads and newts, which would have had difficulties colonising a garden surrounded by busy roads. They were introduced as spawn. The absence of fish has encouraged a thriving population of common frogs and smooth newts. Toads breed here too.

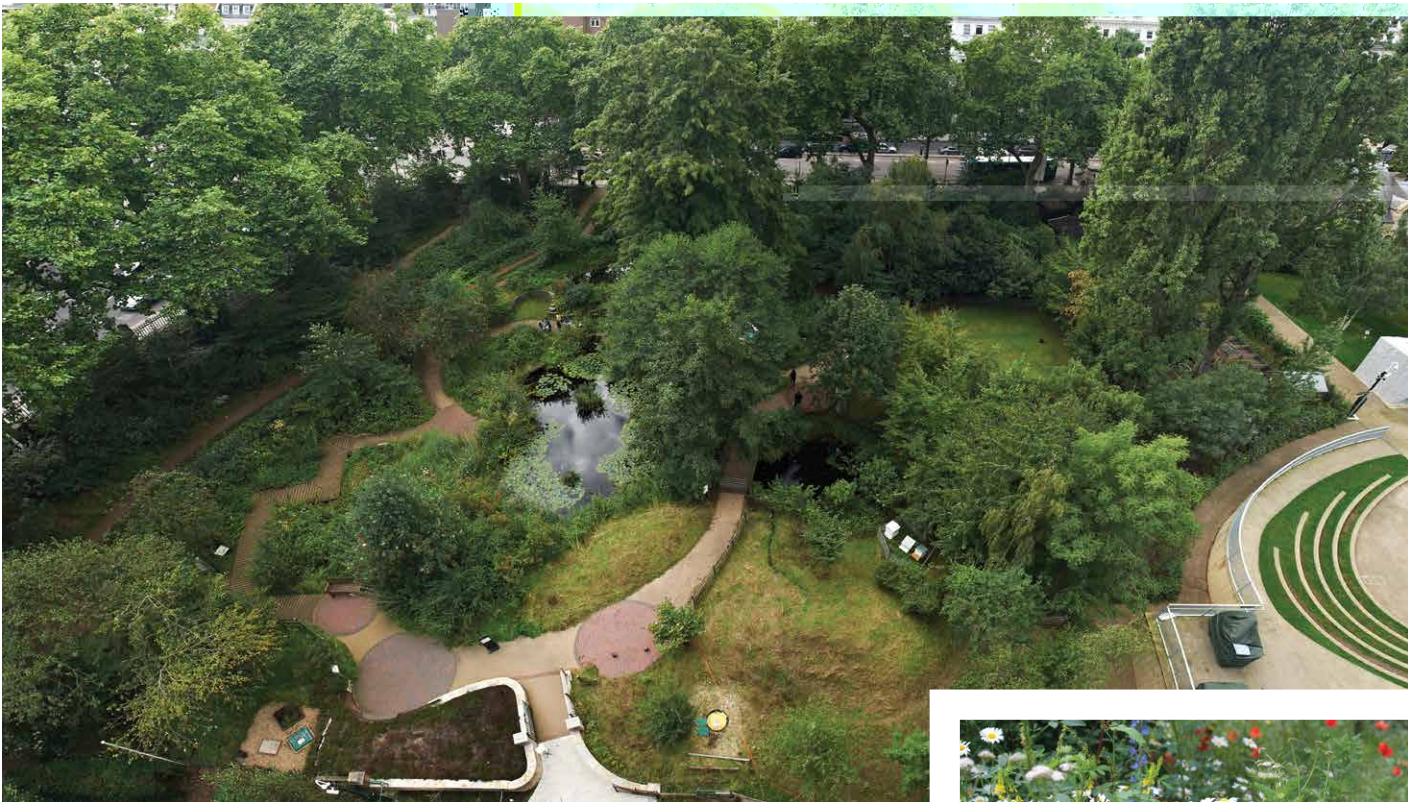
During summer, visitors can see the colourful and aerobic displays of up to eight species of damselflies and dragonflies that breed in the ponds. A family of moorhens are protected from the resident foxes by the provision of a nesting island. The ponds also provide a range of damp habitats at the transition from water to land for many insects and plants. The ponds are an important source of drinking water for insects,

birds and mammals, and the swarms of small insects emerging from the water are snapped up by predators. Several species of bird take advantage of this food source, such as blackbirds, robins, long-tailed tits, great tits and wrens, who also breed in the cover provided by the trees and bushes in the woodland areas. Winter visitors include redwings and mistle thrushes.

RECORDING BIODIVERSITY

English Nature, who provided a substantial portion of the set-up funds, stipulated that a monitoring programme should be instigated to record the species in the garden. A database was set up to hold these records. Many staff and volunteers enthusiastically answered the call to survey the garden and the turnover of plants and animals. These records form the basis of reports published at intervals in the *London Naturalist*. After 20 years this series of papers must represent one of the most extensive and authoritative accounts available charting the long-term development of a small patch of semi-natural habitat in the heart of a large city. And the continued monitoring of wildlife will be of even greater value in 50 and 100 years time.

As well as the expected common species, the garden hosts several animals that are less widespread and have surprised scientists. These include the Jersey tiger moth and the landhopper – a shrimp-like creature that lives in leaf-litter. Several species not previously recorded in Britain, including the micro moths,



Ectoedemia heringella and *Prays citri*, and the beetle, *Rhyzobius forestieri*, were also found. The database currently holds records of more than 2,500 species.

NATURE NURTURE

The garden is a unique resource enthusing visitors of all ages about the natural riches of the English countryside. Science educators and scientists from the Museum lead wildlife tours and pond dipping trips, popular with school groups and amateur enthusiasts. Annual themed events such as Nettle Weekend, Bat Festival and Hedgerow Harvest are also informative and fun for children and adults. There is no better way of kindling an interest in, and respect for, nature than providing hands-on wildlife experiences.

Many children lose interest in natural history during the distracting teenage years, but those who have had vivid wildlife encounters when they were younger often need little encouragement to reawaken those interests as young adults. The garden also acts as a hub for the Museum to be involved with, and provide a resource for, the local community. An active group of local volunteers help the team with tasks throughout the year, gaining skills such as hedge-laying, coppicing and pond management, while benefiting from the exercise and fresh air.

AN OASIS IN METROPOLIS

The Wildlife Garden is a very special place. It's a retreat where visitors and staff can

enjoy tranquil contemplation of the natural world. Visitors of all ages can appreciate and understand how the natural world works and the components that make up ecosystems by seeing them in action. It also provides a means of engaging local communities in conservation activities and improving the local environment by bringing wildlife into the heart of the city.

The garden has been widely recognised as a special place and won several accolades, including the Brighter Kensington and Chelsea Scheme's Wildlife Garden award, and the London in Bloom Environment Trophy in 2004 and 2014. It is now a designated Site of Importance for Nature Conservation (SINC) in the Borough of Kensington and Chelsea.

The last words should go to our visitors: 'what a brilliant adventure – so much to learn and discover. An inspiring introduction to a love of nature.' 'Such an unexpected pleasure. A natural oasis in the centre of London, both exquisite and informative. Blissful to hear the bird song above the traffic. Utterly impressed by the primroses and the dedicated volunteers. Thank you.' And from our international visitors, 'a lovely, unexpected experience of the English countryside on our short trip to England. It made my day.' 'We love the Museum and garden. We could see lots of animals and it's a great way to teach children and adults about nature.'



Top to bottom A 'bird's eye' view of the Wildlife Garden from the west tower of the Waterhouse building. The edges of chalk downland near the entrance to the garden. After the wild flowers have bloomed and set seed the Museum's grey-face Dartmoor sheep are brought in to demonstrate sustainable meadow management. A moorhen striding across a raft of water-lilies.